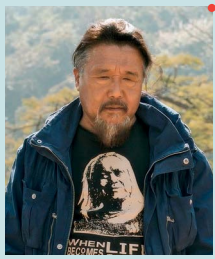
FILMS TO WATCH OUT FOR



THE ELYSIAN FIELD (Meghalaya)

Pradip Kurbah's drama takes place in 2047 in a remote village where only six villagers remain after migrations. A pioneer of Khasi cinema, Kurbah's film emphasises the significance of community in a rapidly changing world.



JOSEPH'S SON (Manipur)

About a father's search for his son and a journey to Imphal to identify what is possibly his corpse. With many languages from the state, **Haobam Paban Kumar**'s drama builds a tense narrative of a region marred by conflict.

NOT A HERO (Assam)

Rima Das' latest follows a city-bred boy sent to his family's ancestral village to stay with his aunt. The stillness and simplicity of village life and a child's coming-of-age occupy this film, which won a special mention prize at the Berlin Film Festival.



ing an audience by renting an 800-seat multipurpose hall in Meghayala's Tura. Says Sangma, "We went out to schools and colleges, spoke to principals and teachers and encouraged students to come and watch by offering a discount. We had three shows a day and the auditorium was packed for three weeks."

Rapture is currently streaming on hellomeghalaya.com, an initiative of the state to platform its cinema—Pradip Kurbah is another filmmaker getting distribution there—but its journey for the mainstream spotlight was tough. "When we approach a major streaming platform, we hear that if you put up a film from a very small place in India, how many people will get a subscription to see it? I think there is some sort of mental block," he says. "They should support films like ours when they have other films that are already making money for them."



"WHEN WE APPROACH A MAJOR OTT PLATFORM, THEY SAY A FILM FROM A SMALL INDIAN PLACE WON'T GET PEOPLE TO SUBSCRIBE"

DOMINIC SANGMA
Filmmaker

SUBVERTING THE SYSTEM

Sangma is one of the lucky ones—"*Rapture*'s release is cited as an example on how independent art house films in India can get visibility." He currently heads the screenwriting department at the Film and Television Institute of India's new Itanagar-based centre, administered by the SRFTI, and has found trusted benefactors in Eva and China's Xu Jianshang. But there are also filmmakers like Manipur's Haobam Paban Kumar, whose last two features, *Nine Hills One Valley* and *Joseph's Son*, still aren't available to stream. He turned to his wife and the National Film Development Corporation to get them made. "When I had moved to Delhi, I realised a lot of people don't know about us [Manipur]. I felt cinema would be the easiest medium to do so," says Kumar, also an SRFTI graduate. "I want to tell stories of Manipur to the rest of the world. These are not very conventional subjects and I mostly work with non-actors. Maybe that doesn't go well with distributors," he adds.

As Rai dominates the festivals with *Shape of Momo*, she hopes its theatrical release in India gives a fillip to more northeastern filmmakers wanting their work to be seen here. "We are so diverse and people watch all kinds of films," she says. "*Itna bada desh hai* [We are such a big country], we can co-exist. *Lekin space banana hai* [We just need to make space]." Rai doesn't know what her next venture will be but she knows it will be set in her village. "People are like, Sikkim is so beautiful, why don't you shoot elsewhere?" she says. "But that's how I think. Also, I live there. So I have no other choice."

However, what the current northeastern films have to do is surpass the record set by Manipur's acclaimed Aribam Syam Sharma's *Ishanou*, which competed in the Cannes' Un Certain Regard category way back in 1991. The story of a woman disturbed by visions and looking for solace in the arts, it is the only northeastern film to reach the prestigious festival. With this rising tide of talent in the region, all bets are off for who will repeat this feat. ■